



*An interview with
Rabbi Yosef Lipsker,
shliach in Reading,
Pennsylvania, and a
licensed addiction and
substance abuse counselor at the
Caron Treatment Centers.*

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What
Every
Shliach
Should
Know
About

ADDI

Many shluchim encounter people who, rachmana litzlan, suffer from addictions to alcohol, drugs, Internet, gambling, and even food. What should a shliach do when an addict turns to him for help, and what should he not do?

Addiction is a serious illness and a highly sensitive field, and it is crucial that shluchim understand the true nature of addicts and addictions in order to help. A shliach can do a lot to guide the addict towards recovery, but he must be aware of his own limitations. Even the most well intentioned person can give very bad advice without proper knowledge or experience.

The shliach must strike a delicate balance between getting involved and knowing when to ask for professional help. Teaching chassidus and influencing the addict to become more frum will not heal the addict. He needs professional guidance from drug counselors and therapists experienced specifically in this field.

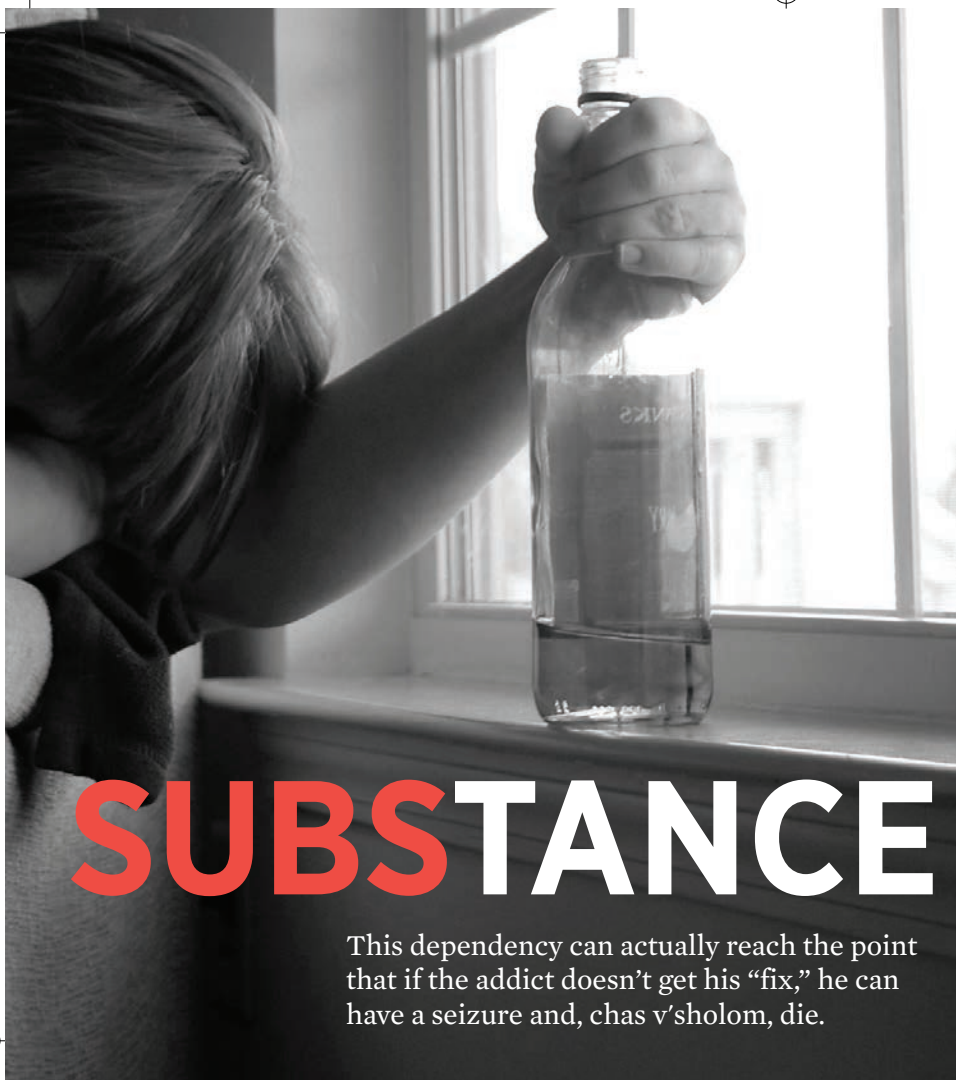
Every case must be evaluated individually, and what worked for one person might actually be damaging for someone else, even if they both had the same addiction. Shluchim should refer the addict to someone whom they trust and who is experienced in recovery.

First and foremost, engage the addict. Build a friendship, and gain his trust. Try to become an influential, positive voice in his life, and try to ascertain the nature and extent of the addiction.

However, shluchim must be careful that, in their attempt to help, they don't inadvertently worsen the problem.

For example, if an addict approaches a shliach for food or money, the shliach's first reaction is to help in any way he can,

ADDITION



SUBSTANCE

This dependency can actually reach the point that if the addict doesn't get his "fix," he can have a seizure and, chas v'sholom, die.

even raising money from his own community. I advise extreme caution when considering this; rehab is extremely expensive, and it's important to be realistic about the frequency of relapses. One shliach raised a substantial amount from his community for treatment for a local addict, who subsequently relapsed, overdosed, and unfortunately passed away. What seems like helping might really be "enabling," doing more damage than good. An active addict would rather spend his last pennies supporting his habit than for his basic needs, often resorting to lying and stealing in their desperation to escape back to the haven their drug provides them. For this reason, paying for some or even all of their treatment is often a part of their recovery.

Unless the addict is truly motivated to change, he will not recover, no matter how much others try to help. I learned this in my early days at Caron. Two lawyers were in treatment simultaneously, one married with a

child, the other a single, without much going for him. One day, I said to the single lawyer, "You have a big problem. You are alone in this world. What motivation do you have to recover? You don't have a marriage or child at stake. What will push you?" He looked me in the eye and said, "Rabbi Lipsker, trust me. I know that I will recover." Sure enough, he did. He got married and today has three children. Meanwhile, the other lawyer ended up falling further into the depths of addiction, losing everything, and destroying his marriage.

Only the addict can save himself.

Regarding alcohol, a warning comes to mind. When someone refuses a l'chaim, be very careful not to pressure him to drink it. Gracefully move on, or offer him grape juice. For a recovering addict, it takes great strength to refuse the alcohol, and even one small l'chaim can be detrimental to his progress. A recovering addict cannot have even have the tiniest amount of the kidush wine.

Tell us a little bit about the nature of addiction.

While all addicts have similar traits, there is a difference between "substance abuse" and "process addiction." Substance abuse is a physical dependency that the body has developed for certain substances, such as alcohol, marijuana, prescription drugs, cocaine, and heroin. This dependency can actually reach the point that if the addict doesn't get his "fix," he can have a seizure and, chas v'sholom, die. Substance addictions kill and cannot be taken lightly. Process addiction is an addiction to an activity or process, such as eating, spending money, using the Internet, or gambling. These can be just as debilitating as addictions to alcohol or drugs. They all require psychological treatment.

Even household medications like sleeping pills or anxiety pills can be addictive and even life threatening. Initially, they simply make the person feel better, but ultimately, if a person needs a substance to feel "normal," something is majorly wrong. It is not okay if a rabbi needs a pill or a shot of alcohol in order to give a speech. The nature of drugs is that, eventually, one needs a stronger dose, and this leads down a slippery slope to harsher addictions.

I was recently working with a woman who began taking a drug for her ADHD. This drug helped her focus and allowed her much success as a banker. However, she became so intense that soon she was unable to fall asleep at night and needed a second pill to calm down and a third to fall asleep. For three years, she was doing well, but then she lost her job, began to shop for clothes obsessively, and, as she craved more drugs, had to turn to dealers when she could no longer get enough medication from her doctor.

When it comes to addiction, we must make all efforts to find the best treatment possible, disregarding the costs and the cold statistics. People often ask me about the percentage of addicts who actually fully recover. My answer to them is that when someone you care for is sick with a life-threatening illness, you do whatever you can to save him, and you don't think about the statistics. The same is true with addiction.



The most successful methods of rehab are the Twelve-Step Programs (Alcoholics Anonymous [AA], Gamblers Anonymous [GA], etc.), which are strongly based on religious faith and demand belief in a "Higher Power." Many AA meetings have a non-Jewish character, with discussion of belief in other religions. Is this kosher for a Jewish addict?

Even if AA were the only program that works (and it is not; there are other treatment modalities), if it demanded beliefs that were avodah zara, it would be treif for Jews to join. However, the truth is that AA is not at all a contradiction to Judaism and Torah, and on the contrary, it is very much aligned with Torah and chassidus. Rabbi Abraham Twerski has written about this extensively, and recently a fellow shliach, Rabbi Shais Taub, wrote a great book, *G-d of Our Understanding*, which explains the twelve steps according to chassidus.

AA is an amazing process that literally walks someone through the transformational process of true tshuva. That said, many halachic issues may arise, for example, the fact that many AA meetings are held in non-Jewish houses of worship. A shliach should consult a rav who is experienced with addiction before advising on this matter. It is important that the rav understand the gravity of the situation, that this could be a case of pikuach nefesh.

What rehab programs are available for someone who is looking to keep kosher, keep Shabbos and yom tov, and stay in touch with a rabbi?

The priority is to find the right program for that person's specific problem.

If someone needs a heart transplant, you first search for the hospital that can help him best, and only then work on finding a Jewish support system there. However, if you have options, obviously a program with Jewish support is best. There are several in Eretz Yisroel and in the United States. At the Caron Foundation, I visit the Jewish patients regularly to strengthen them and help them with their belief in Hashem and in Yiddishkeit, and we offer kosher food and Shabbos and yom tov meals. I am an official Caron staff member, listed as a "consultant for Jewish needs."

How did you get involved in this type of shlichus in general and in Caron in particular?

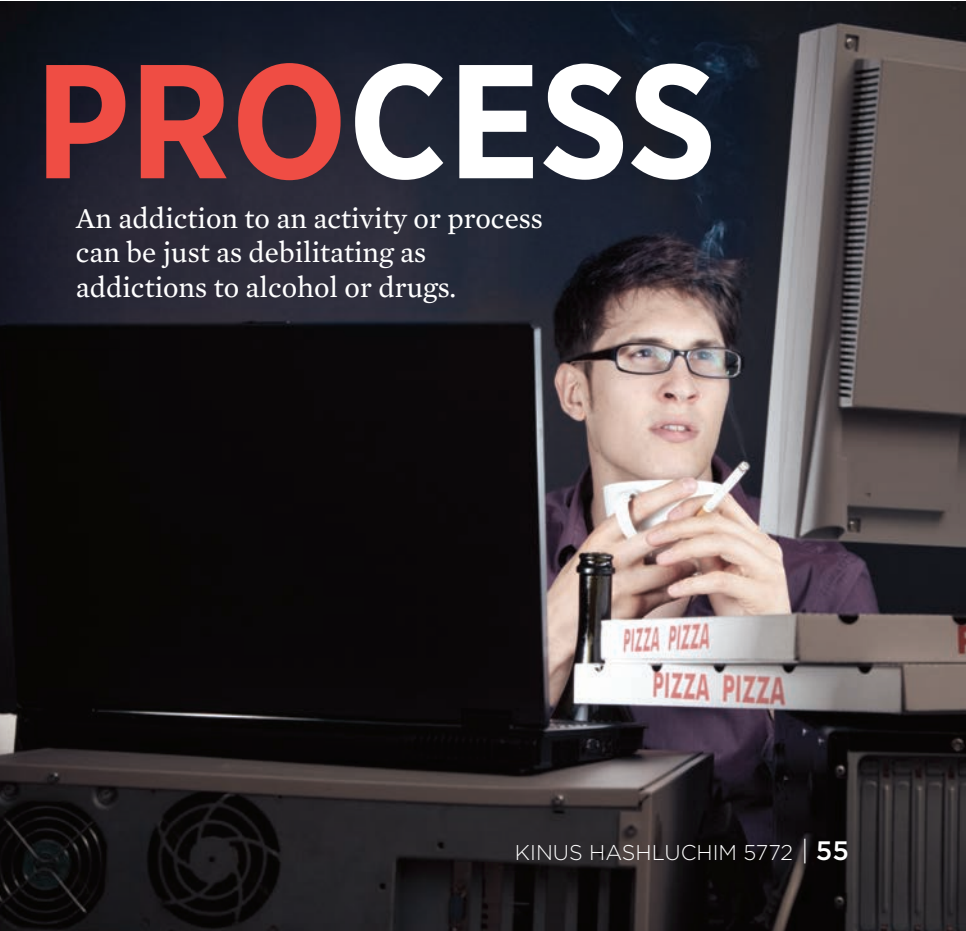
Twelve years ago, a man called me and asked if I could visit him in a rehab center nearby. I assumed he was in rehab for physical therapy, but when I arrived, I quickly realized that this was no ordinary rehab center. The man, sixty years old, opened up about the childhood

abuse he suffered and his cocaine addiction. After two hours, I put on tefilin with him. He cried on my shoulder, then looked up at me and said, "Today is my Yom Kippur." I eventually bought him his own pair of tefilin, and today he is a completely frum Yid who lives in the Old City in Yerushalayim.

This event had a tremendous impact on my life. I got more involved in mitzvot at the center and began to counsel addicts from a chassidic perspective. We developed a Shabbos meal for addicts and their relatives, which was a phenomenal success. Addiction creates a shell around addicts that isolates them from family and friends, but the Shabbos table breaks that shell and connects families. As one young man put it, "I never realized I could have so much fun sober."

Another who was initially reluctant to come later told me, "Cocaine was my addiction, and Shabbos was my cure." Boruch Hashem, we have seen many people become baalei tshuva as a result of these meals.

Caron has strict regulations governing access to communications media during treatment. Except for one phone call



PROCESS

An addiction to an activity or process can be just as debilitating as addictions to alcohol or drugs.

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three times weekly, no cellphones, computers, or Internet are allowed, and no one is permitted to leave the grounds during treatment. However, despite firm guidelines, Caron realized the positive power of the Shabbos meals and made attendance at the rabbi's Shabbos table the *only* exception to their strict rules.

Caron is a very well regarded institution with high standards and excellent programs. Its programs are gender and age specific, and it is about ten percent Jewish at any given time. Although it might be expensive, we work to help those needing treatment into the programs that will be most beneficial to them, and there are scholarships available. Caron often refers people to other rehab centers based on a patient's diagnosis.

Over the years, with more involvement with people in recovery all over the world, it became obvious that further education would be helpful. I got a degree and certification in addictions and substance abuse counseling.

What is the best part about working with addicts?

There is an indescribable energy here at Caron. People are so open, supportive, and respectful of each other's beliefs and journeys. The warmth and friendship is contagious. The grounds are beautiful, and the atmosphere is tranquil, healing, and spiritual. Each person believes in the "G-d of his understanding," which is why they are so respectful of Yiddishkeit, as well. Because there is a turnover every thirty days, the work is always fresh, challenging, and exciting. Recovering addicts are doing amazing avoda pnimis, reaching deep down into a profound and pure place in their neshamos in a way that most people do not. This makes them very receptive to and appreciative of Yiddishkeit and chasidus. For example, for my fortieth birthday, I made the hachlota to get forty men that year to begin putting on tefilin daily. (I actually managed to get forty-one that

year and forty-two the following year.) One was a man who had quit rehab early, a problem I frequently encounter. I asked him to commit to putting on tefilin every day and to call me every Friday to report how it was going. He accepted, and boruch Hashem, today he is still committed to his hachlota and has recovered fully. Unquestionably, the most gratifying thing is when, after a while, I see that the people I helped through their darkest moments are doing better than ever in their personal lives and marriages and have truly found health and happiness.

You host a group of addicts every Shabbos. Isn't it dangerous to expose your young children to this part of life?

A member of my community was very critical of me due to this exact point. He asked me how I could bring these people into my house, especially considering the profanity and promiscuity that are inevitably part of an addict's life. I asked him one question, "If it were your son who fell into addiction, would you still advise me not to bring him into my home?" He paused for a moment, and finally said, "No." The Rebbe taught us that these are our children, and boruch Hashem, in all the years I've been involved in this work, I have never had a problem with negative influence on my family. To the contrary, addicts conform to the Shabbos environment, keeping their behavior appropriate to the family. This unique type of shlichus has been a brocha to us, and my children thank me for the experience. They feel they have witnessed a deeper part of the human condition, enhancing their own path in life. It makes them feel that ashreinu, how fortunate we are to be Yidden, Lubavitchers, and shluchim, and to know and be able to teach the difference between light and darkness. 🇺🇸

Rabbi Lipsker has many years of international experience guiding Jewish addicts toward recovery and hosted a weekly radio program, Mind Over Matter, which was broadcasted throughout the greater Reading area. Rabbi Lipsker can be contacted at lipsker@aol.com or by phone at 610-334-3218.



RECOVERY

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